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– THE POLITICS OF WANGHONG CONSUMPTION: (Re)Making the Place through New Urban Aestheticisation

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Abstract

Why does seemingly innocent wanghong *(online celebrity) consumption—recording appreciation for a place and sharing photos of it on social media platforms—cause neighbourhood changes and instigate exclusionary pressures called 'fashionable people phobia'? Following a critical analysis of this trend in Dongshankou, Guangzhou, I argue that a* new *urban aestheticization process is under way in the digital age, revealing the emergence of a new cultural class in China. This phenomenon is a product of China's domestic digital ecosystem, which produces preferred forms of new urban aesthetics through the power of digital platforms in virtual space, resulting in conflicting cultural representations of Dongshankou in virtual and urban spaces. Due to the interrelated dynamics of digital and urban spaces, the urban transformation of Dongshankou manifests as a new form of urban development mediated by digital technologies rather than gentrification. My argument is based on a comparative analysis of gentrification and the 'fashionable people phobia' phenomenon, which found that the exclusionary pressures are based more on cultural questions around aesthetics than on socioeconomic status change—a result of China's middle-class identity being represented by cultural tastes that depoliticize the importance of social classes.*

Introduction

Dongshankou, a neighbourhood in the city of Guangzhou, China, has recently evolved from a residential area to an enclave of fashionable people and is now one of the most popular consumption places in Guangzhou. During my frequent visits to Dongshankou from 2020 to 2022, I witnessed rapid changes in its retailing landscape and a concomitant and significant transformation of its sociocultural character. Coffee shops, designer brands and chic perfume stores are interspersed with sporadic *siu mei* (Cantonese roasted meat) restaurants, implying that the area used to be a residential neighbourhood occupied by ordinary shops and small groceries to accommodate local residents' everyday needs and livelihoods. Most of the new consumers in Dongshankou are in their twenties. They are often seen standing outside various establishments, dressed in the latest fashion, drinking coffee and continually taking photos. Their consumption activities—posing in front of new stores, taking photographs and then posting them on social media—have turned the area into a *wanghong* consumption hot spot with a high concentration of new retailers that are popular online, and a place with 'fashionable people phobia' (*chaoren kongjuzheng*, 潮人恐惧症),[1] reflecting local

Doing this 'trendy' research feels like a kind of destiny—my name in Chinese 曹流 means 'trend'—and I genuinely enjoyed doing the research fieldwork in Guangzhou. I want to thank people who kindly helped me with my interview and data collection (especially during the lockdowns). I am truly grateful to the IJURR Editors Hyun Bang Shin and Liza Weinstein, for your supportive editorial care. Thanks also to the three IJURR reviewers who encouraged me to challenge myself during the article's revision. Reviewer 1 helped me to refine and rethink some of the original arguments, and reviewer 2, who kept pushing me to be the best version of myself when revising this article; apologies if I have fallen short of your expectations. My gratitude also goes to Carwyn Morris for inviting me to his 'Wanghong Urbanism' workshop, which benefited the later development of this article. This work was supported by the XJTLU Research Development Fund RDF-23-02-053. I declare no potential conflicts of interest with respect to the research, authorship and/or publication of this article.

1 In English the term 'hipster phobia' is sometimes used. Because 'hipster' normally refers to people who reject materialism and mainstream culture, I prefer 'fashionable people', given that *wanghong* consumption is pursued by individuals who are interested in trendy things in China.

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residents' feelings of exclusion in response to new urban lifestyles brought about by fashionable individuals in Dongshankou.

The current situation in Dongshankou is mostly the result of *wanghong* (网红) consumption—a popular form of digital consumption in China that has a strong aesthetic disposition—that impacts young Chinese people's consumption practices while simultaneously transforming the urban space. Originally referring to beautiful models who have a large fan base on Chinese social media, the word *wanghong* has become widely discursive and is broadly used in many contexts, such as place, food and tourism (Zhang *et al*., 2022). A prominent feature of the *wanghong* phenomenon is check-in activities—in which an individual is attracted by something interesting online and subsequently 'checks into' that place/store onsite. Online activities like these reveal how consumption practices are engineered into the design and use of digital platforms, which aligns with the recent discussion of the 'digital turn' in geographical scholarship (Ash *et al*., 2018). Indeed, *wanghong* consumption is a form of digital consumption with an aesthetic disposition, highlighting how new cultural tastes in China are integrated with the use of digital platforms, which amplifies consumption activities in urban areas. Based on this new urban phenomenon in China, this study aims to answer two key research questions: What is the mechanism of Dongshankou's urban transformation under the impact of *wanghong* consumption? How do digitally integrated consumption practices, under the name of *wanghong* consumption, instigate exclusionary pressures in China?

By answering these questions, I aim to contribute to global urban scholarship in two ways. First, acknowledging the powerful role of digital platforms that connect virtual and urban spaces through their interrelated dynamics (Sadowski, 2020), I examine through the lens of retailing changes to understand how digital platforms are involved in producing a new consumption space. My purpose is to gain an understanding of how the new urban space is produced *by* digital platforms that are integrated with Chinese consumers' identities (Ash *et al*., 2018). Second, beyond the endeavour to add to urban studies concerned with the 'digital turn', I provide insights into how new cultural tastes embodied through Chinese people's consumption practices—underpinned by the use of digital platforms—have caused urban changes through the growth of new retail capital. These insights invite the possibility of investigating the consequences of the production of a new consumption space.

My approach differentiates this study from existing scholarship that describes geotagged photos on digital platforms as the cause of urban socio-spatial inequalities through gentrification in the urban material space (e.g. Boy and Uitermark, 2017; Leszczynski and Kong, 2022). Such studies—indeed, Western urban theory in general—have failed to recognize that not all urban transformations lead to gentrification. This article provides an increased understanding of cultural politics, from the perspective of urban consumption, of the way in which meanings are constructed and relations of dominance and subordination established and resisted (Jackson, 2000a). It also explores how *wanghong* consumption vested Dongshankou with particular identities that caused sensory 'othering' under the name of 'fashionable people phobia'—a kind of exclusionary pressure experienced by local residents of the area. Building on pioneering work which analyses cultural capital that initiates urban changes (e.g. 'loft living' in Zukin, 1982), I argue that a *new* urban aestheticization process is under way, a process which integrates Ley's (2003) 'urban aestheticization' with Degen and Rose's (2022) proposal of 'new urban aesthetics' in the digital age. The study thereby extends theoretical boundaries by investigating how new cultural capital produced by digital platforms causes neighbourhood changes through people's consumption practices.

This study was inspired by Shin's (2021) insights on decentring Western knowledge production by 'theorizing from where'. It echoes Robinson's (2016) suggestion of facilitating a more global urban analysis by being alert to locatedness and

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focusing on repeated instances, as well as the endeavour of Teo *et al.* (2023) to develop more global urban studies by theorizing those of urban China. My empirical case study investigates the urban transformation process caused by China's *wanghong* consumption practices by excavating the place politics underlying changes in the consumer landscape. This is important because consumption is not a static phenomenon but 'a complex sphere of relations and discourses assembled, reproduced, and expressed' through the connections with the place (Mansvelt, 2005: 25). Therefore, the consumption perspective offers opportunities to understand local cultures in order to facilitate the generation of grounded knowledge (Robinson, 2006) rather than adding postscripts to Western-originated concepts.

The remainder of this article is organized as follows. First, the key literature in urban scholarship is reviewed to build the conceptual framework of this research, with a particular focus on new retail capital brought about by new urban consumption and lifestyles. Based on this conceptual framework, a discussion of the cultural politics of aesthetics is developed by engaging with recent developments in digital geography. This engagement highlights the importance of understanding consumption as a 'critical social science' rather than viewing it in a simple and one-dimensional way. The following sections present an in-depth empirical case study to show how the influence of *wanghong* consumption is implicated in the processes of urban transformation and the instigation of exclusionary pressures. The article ends with a comparative discussion of existing consumption-side views of urban transformation and the new urban aestheticization process to suggest further research in global urban studies.

New retail capital and neighbourhood change: producing a new consumption space

Geographic research on consumption with a focus on its spatialities, socialities and subjectivities shows that consumption does not simply refer to economic transactions but also reveals consumers' identities, tastes and social status (Jackson and Thrift, 2005; Mansvelt, 2005). Urban landscapes are the confluence of economic and sociocultural changes, which means consumption, identity and place are inextricably linked (Crewe and Lowe, 1995). Places and spaces are connected and become meaningful through consumption practices (Mansvelt, 2005), and many new urban spaces are produced from new urban lifestyles and consumption practices (Zukin, 2009). Accordingly, retail streets are not simply places for consumption but are also vested with particular identities and reflect major consumer consumption preferences under the influence of a 'cultural turn' in economic geography (Crewe and Lowe, 1995; Crang 1997).

Therefore, the growth of new retail capital reflects the materialization of new consumption cultures (Crang, 1997), and the retailing changes reveal the desired consumption pursued by the new users (Bridge and Dowling, 2001). This process can cause significant transformation of a given locality (Hubbard, 2016) as the emerging new retail capital alters the sociocultural character of the area, which in turn triggers neighbourhood changes and even gentrification (Zukin *et al.*, 2009). Zukin *et al.* (*ibid.*) use the term 'gentrification' in relation to the negative impacts of new retail capital, which lead to the displacement of local retail stores and services that long-term residents rely on. Hubbard (2017: 4) illustrates that the process of upscaling and boutiquing in local streets should be theorized as a form of gentrification because 'the remaking of the retail landscape is central to the processes by which the inner city is served up as a *spectacle* to be consumed by the middle classes'.

Western scholars such as Hubbard (2017) and Zukin *et al.* (2009) highlight that the growth of new retail capital results in 'gentrification'. In their view, the urban transformation process caused by a group of new consumers with particular habitus—who have higher socioeconomic status and thus displace the former group of consumers—causes negative impacts such as increased living costs and exclusionary

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pressures. The concept of 'habitus' was developed by the French sociologist Pierre Bourdieu (1984: 170), who defined it as an array of 'classifiable practices and works and the capacity to differentiate and appreciate those practices and products (taste) that represent the social world'. According to Bourdieu (1984; Bourdieu and Johnson, 1993), those with social power monopolize ways of seeing and classifying things according to their 'good' tastes, and class power is the ability to create new forms of discernment (Bridge, 2006b).

Bourdieu's work has one prominent Anglo-American feature: he connects social class with cultural tastes, which has significantly influenced other urban scholars in discussing social distinctions based on issues of cultural and economic capital (e.g. Bridge, 2006a). One of the most famous works in this regard was penned by David Ley (2003), who describes artists—a group of people with cultural capital—as changing the urban cultural look via the 'urban aestheticization process'. In this process, artists are agents bestowing aesthetic status on banal objects and environments that are then commodified into aesthetic consumption places for the middle classes (*ibid.*). Bridge (2006a) links different cultural tastes with social class by arguing that cultural capital can result in concentrations of economic capital, which ultimately causes the displacement of working-class people.

In summary, most Western urban scholars use Bourdieu's class-based models of social identities as they consider social distinctions based on differences in people's consumption; that is, they view cultural tastes as associated with social classes that differentiate people. This partly explains why Western scholars consider the growth of new retail capital (e.g. Zukin *et al.*, 2009; Hubbard, 2017) or the urban aestheticization process (Ley, 1996; 2003) as having caused gentrification. For them, gentrification is the consequence of the presence of new consumers who have cultural capital and a higher socioeconomic status, displacing the former group of consumers who do not.

This consumption-side view of gentrification scholarship reflects the tendency of urban scholars to concentrate their focus on new consumers' economic abilities and purchasing power (e.g. Hubbard, 2017; Cocola-Gant and Lopez-Gay, 2020). In other words, consumption is seen as a *game* in which different social groups compete. They fight to produce a new consumption space, and the growth of new retail capital represents the group with stronger consumption powers—in either cultural or economic aspects—and who thereby gained the 'right' to produce a new consumption space. The narrow examination of consumption from a socioeconomic perspective repeatedly enhances the biased understanding of urban transformation based on Western-originated gentrification. This means that phenomena such as culture-led urban regeneration (Wang and Lau, 2009) have been mislabelled as 'gentrification' in their urban contexts.

More importantly, although Bourdieu's class-based social identities have strongly impacted the analysis of cultural tastes, it is questionable whether his models can be applied beyond the West. Consider China, a socialist country in respect of which scholars contend that social classes remain amorphous and the country lacks cohesiveness in terms of the traditional definitions of class (Tomba, 2004); nevertheless, status tends to be shaped through modes of consumption (Cao, 2023). Yet, can we consider people with cultural tastes as having a higher socioeconomic status than Chinese who do not? As consumption not only refers to economic abilities but also contains cultural meanings about identities and aesthetic dispositions (Jackson and Thrift, 2005), the consequences of the production of a new consumption space are not confined to mere socioeconomic changes but also reflect differences in cultural tastes and aesthetic dispositions (Mansvelt, 2005).

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Cultural politics of aesthetics in the digital age: power, inequality and oppression

Crewe and Lowe (1995) argue that places are invested with particular identities because microgeographies of consumption and retailing are challenging the simplicity of globalization. However, retailers can also be viewed as invested with different identities because of the 'cultural turn' in economic geography (Crang, 1997), as they are materialized objects produced by consumption (Jackson, 2000b). This means that it is crucial to investigate how new retailers with different aesthetics reflect the social identities brought about by new consumers' consumption practices. Beyond merely focusing on the economic aspects of consumption, the cultural perspective reveals how objects are produced with cultural meaning and represent consumers' aesthetic dispositions (Mansvelt, 2005). Therefore, the cultural politics of aesthetics needs to be further explored, as it may perpetuate inequalities of power through consumption (Jackson and Holbrook, 1995). That is to say, the cultural questions of aesthetics cannot be divorced from 'political' questions about power, inequality and oppression (Mansvelt, 2005).

For example, given the problematic categorization of China's middle classes, Pow (2009) points out that the aesthetic appreciation of landscapes acts as a subtle yet highly effective mechanism of social exclusion that depoliticizes the importance of social classes within the Chinese context. This phenomenon has also been observed in other urban China studies of how different cultural tastes, rather than economic abilities, are used to manifest consumers' middle-class cultural identity (e.g. Ning and Chang, 2022; Cao, 2023). Pow's research not only shows how China's middle-class identity is represented through different cultural tastes and urban lifestyles rather than by socioeconomic status alone (Pow, 2009); he concurs with Mansvelt (2005) by highlighting inequalities caused by cultural questions of aesthetics.

Thus, rather than connecting cultural capital with socioeconomic status, Pow's work demonstrates how oppression, inequality and exclusion in China are perpetuated through lifestyles, visual pleasures and 'good tastes' as well as repetitive aesthetic consumption patterns (Pow, 2009). Moreover, he shows how inequality and oppression are exerted through discrimination based on the Chinese people's own judgement of 'good taste' as manifested in their middle-class identities (Pow, 2017). In recent years, research on Chinese middle-class identities through aesthetic consumption has become increasingly detailed and concrete. For example, Ning and Chang (2022: 191) describe a trending phenomenon in Shanghai:

> The Undefined café is regarded as a must visit because of its artistic aura … a stark (but highly 'Instagrammable') black-white scheme … A year after its opening, the outlet has become a *wanghong* (online celebrity) café and is highly rated on lifestyle websites and blogs.

Ning and Chang show how Chinese people manifest a middle-class identity by patronizing *wanghong* cafés with aesthetic décor. However, they do not elaborate on the word 'Instagrammable', a key characteristic of *wanghong* cafés in China, and fail to consider the domestic digital ecosystem, which is associated with Chinese digital platforms rather than Instagram. Nevertheless, their work reveals a new form of retail capital—places that offer a photogenic consumption environment—which has become a recent marketing focus in China's urban consumption.

'Instagrammable' urban images are different from traditional ways of viewing a city's cultural capital according to its physical structures. Rose (2016) highlights the importance of researching digitally mediated cultural production and putting increased focus on digital interfaces to divert from the traditional attentive gaze on stable cultural objects. On the one hand, from computer-generated urban images to tourist selfies

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and social media posts that are created and shared via digital devices, *new* urban aesthetics are created via digital platforms to represent users' feelings and experiences (Bissell, 2020; Degen and Rose, 2022). On the other hand, with filters and special effects, counter-urban images can also be produced, either by removing the negativity and blemishes of the urban (Boy and Uitermark, 2017) or by producing beguiling posts to attract people's attention by denying real urban images (Degen and Rose, 2022).

However, regardless of whether they are pro- or counter-urban images, both types represent a form of *new* urban aesthetics created by users applying multiple photo edits through digital platforms (Degen and Rose, 2022). The 'work' consumers apply through photo editing invests their social identities by producing new urban aesthetics in their preferred forms (Jackson and Thrift, 2005). This raises political questions about which social groups have the right to decide their preferred forms of aesthetics, as they may perpetuate inequalities through their consumption practices (Mansvelt, 2005). In addition, the related dynamics of digital and physical space (Sadowski, 2020) mean that the production of a new consumption space goes beyond the mere power of consumers: it is also produced *by* digital means (Ash *et al*., 2018). Thus the new urban consumption space is integrated with the power of digital platforms.

Despite the inability to access Instagram in China, Ning and Chang's (2022) use of the term 'Instagrammable' conveys that digital platforms are a means to develop a new aesthetic disposition in China—one produced by Chinese consumers who are reliant on the use of digital platforms for their consumption activities. That is to say, *wanghong* cafés not only demonstrate that *wanghong* consumption is a form of digital consumption with an aesthetic disposition; they also reveal how this kind of digital consumption simultaneously incubates a new form of retail capital in China (*ibid*.). By showing how geographies are produced *by* digital platforms (Ash *et al*., 2018), Ning and Chang's work aligns with the prevailing discussions of the 'digital turn' in geographical scholarship.

Therefore, the term 'Instagrammable' begets new cultural questions on aesthetics in China, specifically about what kind of consumers manifest their social identities and produce their preferred aesthetics with the power of digital technologies, causing inequality and oppression. Here I concur with Pow's (2009) work that describes the placemaking process of middle-class landscapes in China. Hence, instead of directly applying Bourdieu's class-based models of social identities, I follow Pow in basing social distinctions in China on differences in cultural tastes. This approach has the benefit of depoliticizing the importance of socioeconomic abilities by adhering to the nature of consumption, as different cultural tastes can also instigate negative impacts such as inequality and oppression (Mansvelt, 2005).

More importantly, given that *wanghong* consumption is a form of digital consumption in China, my study also takes into account recent research that highlights the powerful role of digital platforms in accumulating wealth and stimulating growth (Srnicek, 2017; Rosen and Alvarez León, 2022). Online posts with geotags and hashtags function as the digital capital of a place (Cao, 2024a), revealing how digital consumption is transforming the place through the power of digital platforms. This understanding of transformation is necessary to analyse the consequences of the production of a new digital consumption space and can facilitate comparative discussions with existing gentrification scholarship from the consumption side.

Case study area description and research methodologies

My research site is the neighbourhood called Dongshankou, in the city of Guangzhou. During my two years' observation of this *wanghong* consumption place, the area experienced rapid changes in its retailing landscape, particularly the growth of new retailers focused on providing aesthetic consumption environments. While there are other *wanghong* consumption places emerging in China, I chose Dongshankou as

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the most optimal research area for several reasons. First, unlike *wanghong* consumption locations that have long been high-end retail areas comprising boutiques and exquisite consumption venues (such as many local streets in Shanghai), some retail shops in Dongshankou have continued catering to local residents' daily needs. The recent changes in the area's retail landscape thus allowed me to investigate it in a comparative manner with existing studies such as Hubbard (2017) and Zukin *et al*. (2009), in order to understand whether the growth of new retail capital in China's urban transformation also leads to gentrification.

Second, Dongshankou has an exotic urban landscape—which is considered a middle-class consumption landscape in China (Cao, 2024b)—and is one of the highest-priced housing areas in Guangzhou. Consequently, it is not significantly populated by people of low socioeconomic status as documented by Western gentrification scholarship. In fact, for historical and political reasons, Dongshankou has long been a place with a strong middle-class image, and most of its residents are employed as highly skilled professionals, such as government officials, doctors and university staff. Also, it is one of the school districts (*xuequfang*, 学区房) in Guangzhou where Chinese middle-class parents can send their children to good schools. Thus, Dongshankou offers an optimal opportunity to understand the cultural meanings of consumption in (re)making the place, going beyond the economic perspective of existing gentrification studies.

Beginning in November 2020, I stayed in Dongshankou regularly for a two-year period, including during several pandemic lockdowns, to conduct participant interviews and field observations. Being a young female researcher interested in *wanghong* consumption provided me with an advantage when approaching potential interviewees, as I was similar in age and interests to those whom I needed to interview and observe. I disclosed my research interests and clarified the purpose of the research to obtain participants' consent before engaging them in interviews or observations. Consumers were approached onsite, and different new and old stores in Dongshankou were then jointly visited to enable me to record participants' consumption practices and patterns, and to elicit their impressions of consumption. I also conducted more than 45 semi-structured interviews (all recorded and transcribed by me) with a variety of individuals, including old and new retailers, customers and local residents. Follow-up interviews were conducted via phone calls or on WeChat. Interview questions covered different themes, such as new retailers' motivation to do business in the area, marketing strategies and local residents' feelings about their living areas as *wanghong* consumption places. To better understand responses and behaviours, I used ethnography as the primary research method. Here I follow Ananya Roy (2016: 201), who explains that for her doing urban research in India as ethnography 'generated the necessity … to immerse myself in the "local" literatures that were unrecognised by the "world literature" that is urban theory'. I share her sentiments, as I had to detach myself from the social and spatial categories I have been trained on in the West.

More importantly, visual methodologies (Rose, 2022), such as discourse analysis of visual contents and studying audience, were applied to examine online posts on Xiaohongshu, a social media and e-commerce platform. This involved analysing one image and its interrelated texts, unveiling the meanings carried by these images and texts, and collecting data ethnographically through observations of and interviews with fans and users—that is, people who interacted with those online posts. To obtain these visual data, I used Python to scrape relevant posts on Xiaohongshu by applying the specific word 'Dongshankou', limiting the time period to 2020–2022 and collecting relevant information such as location, hashtags, content, link, user, time and so on. Due to Xiaohongshu being a social media application without an official website (until 2022), the total number of scraped posts was limited to 1,000, but all posts were scraped randomly to ensure data diversity. These posts were subsequently analysed through NVivo in terms of hashtags, content and photo styles to further enrich data collection.

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All interviewees (including Xiaohongshu users who posted publicly) were coded using pseudonyms to maintain research ethics.

Becoming a *wanghong* consumption place: digital capital and new urban aesthetics

As suggested by Ning and Chang's (2022) description of the *wanghong* cafés and restaurants in Shanghai, which usually have fancy decorations and are aimed at providing consumers with the space to take photos for social media, *wanghong* consumption is a form of digital consumption that focuses on the consumption of places/goods with aesthetics (Cao, 2024b). One of the prominent characteristics of *wanghong* consumption is the check-in activities (Zhang *et al*., 2022; Cao, 2024a), where consumers are attracted by something interesting online and subsequently check into that venue onsite. To take advantage of the popular *wanghong* trend, many retailers in China started embellishing their decor to appeal to consumers' *wanghong* consumption desires.

Dongshankou is one of the emerging *wanghong* places in China, with many new (*wanghong*) retailers choosing it as their place of business primarily because its aesthetic urban landscape fits the crucial criterion of *wanghong* consumption in aesthetic environments. Marcia, who used to be an artist, is the owner of a new designer brand in Dongshankou and one of the first new retailers who chose the area as her preferred business location for her independent shop. She explained her motivation for choosing Dongshankou:

> To be honest, at the very beginning, I also doubted my choice to do business here because Dongshankou was not the perfect choice. Though it has an aesthetic urban landscape, it is a residential place mainly used for educational purposes, as you can see [from] these primary schools around [here]. Also, it has a long street that sells vulgar goods and groceries. To be clear, it is a residential place, and the retail types here are very ordinary to accommodate residents' everyday living necessities. Who would like to come here to consume? …
>
> However, after my personal visits and field exploration, I believe Dongshankou has the potential to be a *wanghong* place, and I also believe that the urban landscape and architecture of Dongshankou are an ideal choice for doing business in Guangzhou. As you know, now social media marketing is very important to attract customers; being a *wanghong* store means you must make sure you have an aesthetic environment for [customers] to take photos. Dongshankou's architecture and urban landscape satisfy this basic requirement; as long as its retail levels can be improved, I believe it can attract more consumers and become a *wanghong* consumption place (Marcia, interviewed in August 2021).

The interview with Marcia reveals some key information. First, 'being *wanghong*' has become one of the major means of generating profits in China, mainly because the ubiquitous use of digital platforms has dramatically changed people's consumption practices, and digital capital has become the most profitable resource in the digital age (Sadowski, 2020; Rosen and Alvarez León, 2022). Second, the aesthetic urban environment signalled that Dongshankhou would be a place with steadily growing economic capital (Ley, 2003). In other words, the choice of Dongshankou as a retail location was driven not solely by economic criteria but also by its exotic urban landscape that reflected the middle-class identities these new retailers wanted to accommodate (Crewe and Lowe, 1995; Cao, 2023).

However, the most important insight gleaned from this interview is that ordinary retailers are described by Marcia as 'vulgar' because they cannot satisfy young Chinese

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people's *wanghong* consumption desires—she views people who prefer *wanghong* consumption as a group with high expectations of aesthetic consumption. Therefore, Marcia's discrimination against ordinary retailers in Dongshankou stems from her personal cultural tastes, which manifest in her social identity as one who seeks to provide an aesthetic consumption environment as a *wanghong* retailer. She considers the old-fashioned retailers to be 'vulgar' because she cares more about 'good cultural tastes' when opening a *wanghong* store, rather than seeing Dongshankou as a place that can attract people with more economic spending power.

Different from the existing retailers, new retailers like Marcia focus heavily on providing an aesthetic consumption environment. They use influencers and social media platforms (e.g. Xiaohongshu) as a marketing strategy because *wanghong* consumption relies on digital platforms to facilitate consumers' check-in activities as a way to accumulate wealth (Cao, 2024a). One of the typical examples is a café called Dream Theatre, which was renovated from a dilapidated Victorian-style house in 2020. It is highly photogenic and has an aesthetic consumption environment that perfectly fits the core requirements of a *wanghong* store.

The new retail capital brought by retailers like Dream Theatre shows how digital platforms are involved in producing new urban aesthetics through Chinese consumers' consumption activities. Bella, a wedding planner and owner of Dream Theatre, described how she had retained the services of an emerging influencer named Linlin from among her personal connections to showcase the café on digital platforms. (She explained that she did not hire established influencers because they were too expensive.) Linlin's posts about Dream Theatre on Xiaohongshu (where she has over 60,000 followers) show that it was glamorized through filters and affective content, with a strong focus on describing the café as highly photogenic, a sort of spiritual enclave that will 'make you feel like a princess' (adapted from Linlin's Xiaohongshu post in October 2020).[2]

One of my interviewees, Vivi, a university student in her early twenties, revealed that Dream Theatre's consumption environment attracted her to Dongshankou. During participant observation, Vivi told me that she came to this café because she wanted to take photos in a particular corner as it provided the best spot for photography, which mirrored what many others had conveyed with 'likes' and complimentary comments on Xiaohongshu. As Vivi wrote in her Xiaohongshu post, edited with underlined English tags: 'Dream Theatre's decorations and design definitely satisfied all girls' dreams! It is highly photogenic; when you take photos here, you will feel like you are in a foreign country. #OOTD #Dongshankou #*InsFeng* (InstagramStyle)' (Vivi, posted in August 2022; see Figure 1).

Vivi's post advised that 'Dream Theatre satisfied all girls' dreams', which parallels Linlin's post illustrating the dreamed-of urban lifestyle of feeling 'like a princess' when consuming at Dream Theatre. Figure 1 is just one of many examples of how Dongshankou is rebranded through crafted photos with hashtags and geotags in virtual space. Through Xiaohongshu, Dongshankou has been given a new cultural image as a place full of aesthetic consumption that can satisfy one's dreams of urban life. However, when Dongshankou was only just becoming popular on Xiaohongshu, around 2021, some online posts created confusion for both local residents and new consumers due to the use of editing tools available on digital platforms that changed the cultural representation of the area (Degen and Rose, 2022; Leszczynski and Kong, 2022). For example, at the early stage of my fieldwork, a local resident, who grew up in Dongshankou, told me that he was confused about the conflicting cultural representations of Dongshankou when he was browsing Xiaohongshu:

2 https://www.xiaohongshu.com/explore/5d36ce770000000027023699?xsec_source=pc_feed.

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> West Miaoqian Street [the most popular street in Dongshankou] used to be a street of vulgar clothing shops; local residents like us call it a *lanjie* (烂街) [a street with messy goods]. However, it suddenly became a *wanghong* consumption place on Xiaohongshu! I was so shocked when I was browsing Xiaohongshu that if I hadn't noticed that they wrote it as Dongshankou, I definitely would not believe those photos were taken in Dongshankou. I have to admit Xiaohongshu is so powerful [by faking something vulgar as something beautiful] (Mr Wong, around 30 years old, interviewed in October 2021).

On the one hand, Mr Wong's comments demonstrate the powerful role of digital platforms, which are capable of 'faking' Dongshankou as a place with interesting and beautiful elements, changing the cultural manifestation of the area through glamorized photos in virtual space (Leszczynski and Kong, 2022). On the other hand, filtered and crafted photos produced through digital platforms are Dongshankou's *new* cultural capital (Rose, 2016) and are sometimes even deceptive due to the editing capabilities of these platforms (Degen and Rose, 2022; Leszczynski and Kong, 2022). Conflicting cultural representations caused by *wanghong* consumption reveal how users use digital



年度一定要去的咖啡店｜DreamTheater梦剧场

FIGURE 1 Vivi's edited photo of Dream Theatre on Xiaohongshu. Translated, her caption reads: A must-visit coffee shop of the year: Dream Theatre (*source*: adapted with permission from Vivi's Xiaohongshu post)

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platforms to promote new urban aesthetics in their preferred forms through filtered and glamorized photos.

As online posts with geotags about Dongshankou became the digital capital of the area (Cao, 2024a), new rounds of consumers and investment were attracted to the neighbourhood—evidence that digital capital is now the most profitable resource and the newest engine for urban development (Rosen and Alvarez León, 2022). Many new investors and retailers are attracted to the area because the *wanghong* economy has become one of the most profitable methods of doing business in China (Cao, 2024a). Figure 2 shows the physical transformation that took place in Dongshankou between 2020 and 2022; most of the new retailers were drawn to the area because of its high popularity on Xiaohongshu. A typical example is the Dongshankou wet market, a place where local residents have long bought their daily food (Figure 2.4). An upscaling process has turned the establishment from a 'vulgar' wet market into a beautifully designed *wanghong* market. It is now a photogenic place where young Chinese people use tripods and professional cameras to take photos using the market as a backdrop.

Similarly, West Miaoqian Street in Dongshankou, which was regarded by local resident Mr Wong as 'a street with messy goods' because it was largely occupied by 'vulgar' retailers such as fake luxury shops or clothing stores, is now populated by new retailers that have a strong focus on providing 'Instagrammable' consumption environments (Figure 2.3). These new retailers and their associated aesthetics have attracted more customers and made Dongshankou a popular consumption space. Even the neighbourhood's inner areas, where local residents still live, are occupied by new



FIGURE 2 The physical transformation that took place in Dongshankou from 2020 to 2022: 1) inner residential area occupied by new consumers; 2) the hardware shops that used to line this street have been replaced by coffee shops; 3) West Miaoqian Street, the most popular place in Dongshankou, formerly a site of clothing shops and education institutes; 4) upscaled wet market (photos by the author, 2020–2022)

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consumers (Figure 2.1). Another part of Dongshankou, which used to be a street of hardware shops, has been transformed into a street lined with new retailers providing an aesthetic appearance and selling coffee and light meals (Figure 2.2).

The changes in Dongshankou represent a *new* urban aestheticization process that shows the interrelated power of digital platforms and consumers in transforming a place. Because these new urban aesthetics were produced *by* digital platforms (Ash *et al*., 2018; Degen and Rose, 2022), they became the digital capital of Dongshankou (Cao, 2024a), which helps it attract new waves of investment and consumers, stimulating urban development. New retailers strongly focused on providing aesthetic and photogenic consumption environments have effectively changed the area's cultural representation. Therefore, the physical changes that have taken place in Dongshankou cannot be regarded simply as the result of new consumption practices; the powerful role of digital platforms in causing urban transformation also needs to be acknowledged.

'Fashionable people phobia': exclusion and inequality instigated through cultural tastes

As we have seen, the development of Dongshankou cannot be separated from the power of digital platforms. With the growth of new retailers focusing on providing aesthetic consumption environments, Dongshankou has been transformed into a so-called *wanghong* consumption place. Its high concentration of new restaurants and cafés with aesthetic features can accommodate Chinese consumers' *wanghong* consumption desires. New rounds of consumers with different aesthetic dispositions who are interested in *wanghong* consumption are attracted to the area to showcase their new lifestyles. Figure 3 depicts a common phenomenon in Dongshankou, where new retailers with aesthetic decor attract not only people who work as Taobao (Chinese e-commerce platform) models, but also new consumers who dress fashionably and use these new retail shops as the background for the photos they take.

The new urban aestheticization process taking place in Dongshankou has produced a new consumption space that incorporates the power of digital platforms. Relying heavily on these platforms, new consumers with *wanghong* consumption desires succeed in competing with the area's original residents and consumers, gain the right to produce a new consumption space with their aesthetic dispositions and invest in the area with their social identities through these new retailers. In contrast to the view of Crewe and Lowe (1995), in which retailers exhibit their cultural preferences when choosing places to do business, these new retailers are materialized cultural objects of *wanghong* consumption (Jackson, 2000b), and Dongshankou has been given a different identity that is reflected by these new retailers. It is therefore essential to unpack



FIGURE 3 Fashionable people and Taobao models use the urban space or new stores in Dongshankou as background when taking photos (photos by the author, 2020–2022)

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the consequences of the production of *wanghong* consumption spaces to understand whether Dongshankou has also experienced gentrification. However, unlike classic gentrification scholarship, which discusses negative impacts such as displacement and social class conversion, the empirical data indicate that what has happened in Dongshankou shows how differences in cultural tastes rather than economic changes cause a strong sense of exclusion and inequality.

The data analysis of the content scraped from Xiaohongshu reveals that one of the most frequently mentioned terms is 'fashionable people phobia', which describes the 'fashion bullying' and feelings of inferiority experienced by local residents in relation to the new consumers in Dongshankou. Local residents stated that they were subjected to exclusionary pressures because their cultural tastes were considered to be not as good as those of fashionable people. Both online posts and interviews with local residents confirmed their sense of inequality and oppression after Dongshankou's transformation into a *wanghong* place. Mei, a local resident, described the growing sense of inferiority she felt when living in Dongshankou:

> I used to go outside wearing normal clothes, even pyjamas, and without washing my face to buy breakfast. However, now I feel like a *tugou* (土狗) [slang for 'people who do not look fashionable'] and feel inferior to these new visitors (Mei, female, around 25 years of age, interviewed in April 2022).

Ms Ng, who had been living in one of Dongshankou's small villas for over 30 years, stated that she had wanted to move out of the area at some stage because of the recent disturbances she had experienced:

> When it comes to weekends, it gets even worse. Lots of young people came here and just stood in front of my house, taking photos all the time, which really invaded my privacy. I do not dare to hang my clothes outside, and I am annoyed to be taken into their photos. Sometimes they are so noisy, wearing weird clothes with strange make-up, that I even reported them to the police office [for being noisy in the evening] (Ms Ng, over 60 years old, interviewed in March 2022).

References to 'weird clothes' and 'strange make-up' reflect Ms Ng's negative attitudes towards the fashionable lifestyles of Dongshankou's new consumers. For both Mei and Ms Ng, their sense of exclusion, oppression and inequality reflects different attitudes towards the cultural tastes of new consumers who exert their political power (Mansvelt, 2005).

One question is whether these new cultural tastes represent stronger purchasing power. Interestingly, the new *wanghong* retailers, who have a strong focus on providing aesthetic consumption environments, noted that new consumers often come to their stores to take photos rather than to make purchases. A typical response is as follows:

> I know Dongshankou is now a popular *wanghong* place, and many people want to take advantage of its popularity to make money. My suggestion is, *do not come* [to Dongshankou to do business]. On the one hand, the rental fees are continuously growing, and the cost for me to do business here is very high; on the other hand, photos about Dongshankou on Xiaohongshu indeed helped to attract customers, but the fact is most of the people come here to take photos—very few of them will consume [by paying money] (Mr Chan, owner of a coffee and barber shop in Dongshankou, interviewed in October 2022).

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Mr Chan's comments confirm once again that Dongshankou is now a profitable place because online posts function as digital capital (Cao, 2024a) which helps attract new customers. He and other new retailers wanted to do business in the area because the high volume of online activity led them to believe it was an ideal place to generate profits (Rosen and Alvarez León, 2022; Cao, 2024a). However, as Mr Chan stated, these new consumers are more intent on taking photos rather than engaging in economic transactions. Thus, these visitors' consumption in Dongshankou was less about employing their strong purchasing power than about exhibiting their cultural tastes by taking photos to post on social media and appreciating the area's middle-class landscape (Cao, 2024b).

The empirical evidence therefore indicates that it is not socioeconomic abilities but rather different cultural tastes that cause inequality and feelings of exclusion. According to Mansvelt (2005), inequality and oppression can also be caused by different responses to cultural questions of aesthetics. The next important question to be answered is whether this inequality is associated with socioeconomic status. The forementioned interviewee Marcia, as a *wanghong* retailer, described the traditional retailers as 'vulgar' because they cannot accommodate young Chinese consumers' *wanghong* consumption desires. Yet, are these new *wanghong* retailers really high-end because they provide aesthetic consumption environments, while the Cantonese bakeries, *char siu* restaurants, groceries and clothing stores, which accommodate local residents' daily lives, are vulgar consumption places and serve a group of people from lower socioeconomic levels? In other words, can Dongshankou be considered a place now being consumed by a group of people of higher socioeconomic status only because these *wanghong* retailers provide aesthetic consumption environments?

The empirical evidence collected from Dongshankou strongly suggests that the answer is no. For example, according to fieldwork data collected during interviews with local residents, questions such as 'whether the increased living costs have made you experience displacement pressures' were met with interviewees' expressions of disgust towards these new consumers, who were seen as misusing the local residents' living space by wearing 'weird' and revealing clothing or inappropriately acting out their different lifestyles. Dongshankou is still a residential neighbourhood surrounded by good primary schools, and middle-class parents who could afford houses in this desirable school district were concerned about these consumers' 'wrong' lifestyles and non-mainstream clothing having a negative impact on their children.

Ms Yip, another of the interviewees, is a local resident who grew up in Dongshankou and now works at one of the prestigious universities in Guangzhou. She has been in contact with me since my fieldwork began in 2020. Early on, when the area started getting popular, she told me in 2021 that 'these new retailers have made Dongshankou more interesting and comfortable to live in'. However, in late 2022, she complained that all the new retailers offered similarly decorated aesthetic consumption environments and served mostly coffee—prompting her to question whether people really needed to drink so much coffee! The displacement pressure that Ms Yip experienced stemmed from the disappearance of the diversity of retailers in Dongshankou, revealing how new retailers were becoming homogeneous by erasing local identities. This bottom-up process demonstrates that the geographies of retailing and consumption are closely connected to the identities of major consumers in remaking the place. Under the new urban aestheticization process characterized by new retailers with similar aesthetic décor, the digitally mediated urban development in Dongshankou destroyed the diversity of people's everyday surroundings by homogenizing the place through similar decorations and consumer offerings.

The developments in Dongshankou disclose how *wanghong* retailers and young Chinese consumers are using different cultural tastes and urban lifestyles to manifest their social identities. As inequality and oppression can be triggered by different cultural

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tastes (Mansvelt, 2005), Dongshankou does not follow Bourdieu's (1984) model of class-based social identities but concurs with Pow's (2009) view that China's middle-class identity is displayed through differences in cultural tastes and lifestyles as well as repetitive consumption practices, which depoliticize the importance of social classes. Therefore, as a consequence of the production of a new consumption space in Dongshankou, 'fashionable people phobia' shows how aesthetic consumption and different cultural tastes represent Chinese people's middle-class identities and cause exclusionary pressures.

This analysis makes clear that the consequences of the new urban aestheticization process happening in Dongshankou cannot be regarded simply as gentrification, because research does not confirm that these new consumers of *wanghong* consumption have better economic abilities. The consequences relate more to the cultural politics of aesthetics. The powerful role of digital platforms amplifies the importance of cultural tastes, which then affect the urban environment through rapid retailing changes. Therefore, Dongshankou shows a new urban phenomenon in China driven by the pervasive use of digital platforms in stimulating urban development (Rosen and Alvarez León, 2022), and *wanghong* consumption places like Dongshankou are the manifestation of urban development and consumption mediated by the use of digital technologies. 'Fashionable people phobia' caused by the production of a *wanghong* consumption space reveals how inequality and oppression can be instigated by differences in cultural tastes (Mansvelt, 2005), in contrast to mere socioeconomic conversions that are documented in gentrification scholarship.

Conclusion

At the conclusion of my fieldwork in August 2022, West Miaoqian Street, the most popular street in Dongshankou, teemed with young Chinese people taking photos in front of the new *wanghong* stores. A high percentage of conventional retailers had been replaced by fashionable new stores that were decorated with new aesthetics. The associated retailing changes in Dongshankou—from ordinary to fashionable consumption—share some features with retail gentrification (e.g. Hubbard, 2017). However, it would be an oversimplification to view this process as mere gentrification while ignoring the consequences brought by the production of a new consumption space. Indeed, a key value of investigating Dongshankou's urban changes is that it captures a broader picture of China's urban transformation.

This article endeavoured to provide insights into the mechanism of urban transformation and to avoid falling into the trap of gentrification, in which people of higher socioeconomic status with cultural capital replace the original residents by transforming a place into an area of middle-class usage and consumption (e.g. Hubbard, 2017; Cocola-Gant and Lopez-Gay, 2020). The case of Dongshankou, analysed from a consumption perspective, shows that the mechanism of urban transformation is a *new* urban aestheticization process occurring in the digital age. The new consumption space produced in Dongshankou incorporates the power of digital platforms. The accumulated online posts about the area function as its digital capital (Cao, 2024a), enhancing its image as a profitable place in the digital age (Srnicek, 2017; Rosen and Alvarez León, 2022). This in turn has attracted new retailers with different aesthetics that change the retailing landscape and cultural representation of the place. Dongshankou's transformation can be ascribed to the power of digital platforms in promoting it as a profitable place rather than to new consumers having stronger purchasing powers and economic abilities.

The similarities that the new urban aestheticization process shares with gentrification will undoubtedly lead some to fall into the trap of gentrification. Instead of making another alternative interpretation of gentrification with 'Chinese characteristics', this study argues that the key point in destabilizing the hegemony of

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gentrification scholarship is to understand the consequences of urban transformation. 'Fashionable people phobia', one such consequence in Dongshankou, shows how new cultural tastes are amplified by the use of digital platforms, which ultimately affects the urban environment. In this vein, I follow Pow (2009), who contends that China's middle-class identity is reflected in aesthetic disposition, while social class is depoliticized through differences in cultural tastes and urban lifestyles. The sense of exclusion and inequality are instigated by differences in cultural tastes (Mansvelt, 2005), rather than class-based social identities (Bourdieu, 1984), because digital platforms amplify the power of the new consumers' cultural tastes.

This study also provides guidance on future research related to the analysis of how a place's popularity increases online (*wanghong* consumption) through the process of retailing changes. I depict a bottom-up process in which local retailers are materialized cultural objects produced by the majority of new consumers in remaking the place with new identities. I also show how a group of young Chinese consumers with *wanghong* consumption proclivities are appropriating the middle-class landscape of Dongshankou (Cao, 2024b). The new urban aestheticization process shows the emergence of China's new cultural class, who grew up under the country's rapid urbanization and who are significantly impacted by domestic digital platforms (e.g. Taobao, Weibo and Xiaohongshu). Their cultural tastes and consumer preferences reveal the role of China's own digital ecosystem in incubating the country's new middle-class consumption and signpost a potential new urban phenomenon in the digital age. When a place has evident middle-class features, cultural tastes may even surpass the role of socioeconomic abilities in accelerating urban transformation—a new form of (re) making of the place underpinned by the powerful role of digital platforms.

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